

# MSCF COVER LETTER GUIDE

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Your cover letter is a marketing tool which gives the employer a more detailed view into your candidacy. It acts as a bridge to connect your resume to the position and conveys your ability to communicate.

## Content Development:

### **Make a list of experiences and skills that match the position description**

Review the position description and choose the most important skills the position requires, then select three of those skills you'd like to highlight in your cover letter based on experience you have with a specific focus on those not included in your resume. Provide evidence of these skills by sharing specific examples or stories for each one.

### **Highlight transferable skills**

If you lack "direct" relevant experience, supplement your resume with transferable skills. Transferable skills are those learned through research, work experiences/internships, class projects, extracurricular activities, or student organizations that can be transferred to the position for which you're applying. Try to keep each to only one sentence. They are often soft skills, such as teamwork, leadership, or communication skills. Even if you have direct experience, transferable skills are always of interest to employers.

### **Emphasize your interest in the company and position**

The employer not only wants to know if you can do the job, but also if you've done your homework! Research the company to identify why you want to work there. What about this company (e.g., products, clients, mission, deals, corporate culture) excites you? Share your knowledge of the employer in your cover letter to convince the reader you would be a great fit. However, don't forget that the purpose of this letter is to highlight "why they should WANT to meet you", not just "why you want them".

### **Personalize elements of your letter**

Cover letters don't have to be dry and boring. Tell a story that engages the reader! Personalize your letter by including unique experiences that differentiate you as a candidate. Talk about your passion for the industry or what motivates you to be in the field.

## Formatting:

### **Layout**

You can use a standard business letter format or place the same header (contact information section) used on your resume at the top of your cover letter page, followed by the date and your letter text. Place your closing and typed, full legal name at the bottom of your letter. **Cover letters should be no longer than one page.**

### **Proofread**

Avoid typos, misspelled words, and incorrect grammar. Always have someone else proofread your cover letter before submitting.

### **Use consistent formatting**

Use the same font and font size used in your resume, as this helps brand all of your job/internship search documents, creating an organized and detail-oriented appearance.

### **Address the letter to someone specific**

Find the hiring manager's name and address your letter to this person. If you can't find the correct person, address the letter to "Dear Hiring Manager" or "Dear 'Position Name' team" and avoid impersonal phrases such as "To whom it may concern" or "Dear Sir or Madam." Use proper salutations, such as Dr./Mr./Ms., when appropriate.

### **Mention any contacts you have at the company**

If you know someone who works at the company (perhaps an alumni connection or an internal recruiter that you networked with or referred you for the position); you should also mention the specific function where you met (if applicable) and state his/her name in the first paragraph and explain your relationship. Some recruiters say that this "first and last name" are the two most important elements of a cover letter. However, please only include employees that you know will recognize your name.

## Avoid the following mistakes:

- Apologizing for skills you don't have—instead, focus on what makes you most uniquely qualified.
- Using a standard cover letter for all positions—one size does not fit all! Customize each cover letter you write.
- Restating bullets used in your resume. Be sure to use your cover letter as an opportunity to (a) highlight skills mentioned in the job description that are NOT in your resume, or (b) expand further on the details of your resume.
- Starting the first sentence with your name—the reader can see your name at the top/bottom of your resume so there is no need to waste this precious real estate.
- Forgetting to state the company and position for which you're applying.

## Quick-reference Cover Letter Outline:

See QFC Recruiting Guide for cover letter examples that demonstrate the below formats.

### Conventional Format

|                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opening Paragraph | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Position and company to which you are applying</li><li>• Current university and program in which you are enrolled</li><li>• Thesis statement summarizing 1-2 reasons you are most qualified for the position, in the order of how you will discuss these in the body of your cover letter</li><li>• Name(s) of company contacts you have made</li><li>• Specific interests in company to provide evidence you've done your research</li></ul>          |
| Body              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Use topic sentences to provide an overview of the most important information in the paragraph or section in case someone is scanning your letter quickly</li><li>• Provide specific examples of evidence to support the skills you discuss—tell your story!</li><li>• Include results, feedback you've received on the project/experience, challenges you've overcome, or additional information that will give the reader the whole picture</li></ul> |
| Closing Paragraph | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Ask for the interview!</li><li>• Provide specific instructions on how you may be contacted (phone/email), and mention dates/times if you will be in the area the employer is located on a specific date/time</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

### Hybrid Format

|                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opening Paragraph             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Position and company to which you are applying</li><li>• Current university and program in which you are enrolled</li><li>• Names of company contacts you have made</li><li>• Specific interests in company, providing evidence you've done your research</li></ul>                                                            |
| Transitional Sentence to Body | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• "Here is how I can immediately contribute to your team:"</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Body                          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Choose 2-3 skills to highlight (these should align with the position description)</li><li>• Start by naming the skill in bold, followed by a colon (e.g., <b>Mathematical Modeling:</b>)</li><li>• Follow each bolded skill with a sentence or two describing your experience and giving supporting examples/stories</li></ul> |
| Closing Paragraph             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Ask for the interview!</li><li>• Provide specific instructions on how you may be contacted (phone/email), and mention dates/times if you will be in the area the employer is located on a specific date/time</li></ul>                                                                                                         |

## Conventional Format Example

Sara Smith  
123 Cherryhill Ln.  
Pittsburgh, PA 15213  
412.555.6543  
saras@andrew.cmu.edu

September 5, 2018

Deutsche Bank  
Global Markets Program  
60 Wall Street  
New York, NY 10005

Dear Mr. Hewitt:

My association with Deutsche Bank goes back to 2008 when I was recruited into DB's Global Markets Center in Mumbai. I worked with the Debt Capital Markets rates derivatives marketing team for North America headed by Ashley Jones in New York. I led a team in marketing interest rate risk management solutions to corporations, banks, and insurance companies. Additionally, I have worked extremely closely with Bill Wu under the leadership of Maxwell Patel on the DCM rates team in New York. My two years with DB have been the most influential and thrilling period of my life so far, and the bank's motto of "Passion to Perform" has made a deep impact on the way I respond to situations and manage projects.

I am very excited to apply for the Global Markets Summer Associate Program at DB, and my education, coupled with my prior knowledge of DB systems, culture, and expectations makes me a solid candidate. I joined the Master's in Computational Finance program at Carnegie Mellon University to sharpen my quantitative skill set, with the desire to return to DB in New York after graduation and complement my skills. I have an undergraduate degree in engineering from the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) and am a Level III candidate in the CFA program. I have a strong foundation in DB Analytics, Bloomberg, Excel, and other systems at the bank, which will provide a seamless transition to the summer program.

These interactions over time have made me confident of having a successful career at DB. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my qualifications further during an interview. I can be reached by phone (412.555.6543) or email (saras@andrew.cmu.edu) and look forward to speaking with you soon.

Sincerely,  
Sara Smith

## Hybrid Format Example

Jing (Chelsea) Zhang

412.555.1235

jzhang@andrew.cmu.edu

September 8, 2018

Dear Hiring Manager,

I'm very excited to submit my application to join the Market Risk Group at Morgan Stanley. After speaking with Jane Wu at the Carnegie Mellon University campus recruiting event, I quickly became excited about the broad scope, rigorous nature, and strong research component of the position, which fits well with my core strengths and interests. I am confident that my quantitative skills and education, experience with financial data, and commitment to leadership will add value to the team at Morgan Stanley.

As a candidate, here is how I can immediately contribute to your team:

**Passion for data:** In my past research and internship experiences, I developed a passion for the application of math in the real world. I conducted data-driven econometric research that was a very impactful experience, and one that led me to understand the power and complexity of quantitative analysis with real-world data. I am currently interning at Smith Group focusing on data science and asset management. This has not only expanded my analytical and statistical skills, but also strengthened my teamwork, communication and presentation skills.

**Initiative and Leadership:** I've always taken interest in leading people toward common goals, thus making a positive impact on people, society, and the world. By translating my personal interests in data science into actions, I co-founded the Data Science for Finance Club at Peking University. I built a five-member team, and organized study groups, a 7-lecture series, 10 coffee chats, and a monthly speaker series. To bring best practices using data science in finance to campus, I facilitated the launch of an Industry Leader Talk with speakers from China's top four banks, which attracted more than 200 students. Through these passion projects, I learned invaluable leadership and people skills that are necessary to thrive at Morgan Stanley.

I would appreciate the opportunity to meet with you and discuss how my quantitative background can add value to your Risk team. I can be reached by phone or email to schedule an interview. I look forward to speaking with you soon.

Sincerely,  
Jing (Chelsea) Zhang